

Limitations of Anonymous Grad Cafe Data

Grad Cafe data is useful for learning SQL because it contains many real-looking application records, but it is not a representative sample of all graduate school applicants. The site depends on anonymous self-submission, so the data can overrepresent people who are especially motivated to report good news, bad news, or unusual outcomes. It can also contain missing values, inconsistent labels, duplicate-looking entries, rounding, exaggeration, or mistakes because there is no admissions office verifying each GPA, GRE score, school name, program, or decision status. Those limits mean the SQL answers should be read as patterns in the submitted Grad Cafe records, not as official statistics about graduate admissions.

The latest SQL run reinforces those limitations. In the current database, 31458 records are Fall 2026 entries, 37.09 percent of Fall 2026 entries are acceptances, and 47.70 percent of all rows include comments. The metric averages are GPA: 3.75, GRE Q: 165.81, GRE V: 160.41, GRE AW: 4.34 after filtering to expected reporting ranges for GPA, GRE Quant, GRE Verbal, and GRE Analytical Writing. That filtering makes the averages more comparable to standard score reporting, but it does not solve deeper self-reporting problems because applicants may still omit scores, misstate values, or selectively report unusually strong outcomes. Similar selection and formatting effects can affect acceptance rates, GPA averages, and school-specific counts. The data is still valuable for exploratory analysis, but the results describe anonymous self-reported entries, not verified admissions outcomes.